

Seminar in Semantics: Indefinites

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Description. Static and dynamic approaches to the semantics of indefinites (and definites). Their referential vs. quantificational status and their scopal properties (exceptional wide scope). 'Unusual' indefinites: bare NP's, wh-indefinites (in correlatives, free relatives, questions etc.), free choice items, negative polarity items etc. Indefinites, adverbs of quantification and focus.

Instruction: Sept 24 – Dec 7. Weeks of instruction: 10 (Thanksgiving Recess: Nov 19-23).

Administrative issues:

- the class time needs to be shifted due to scheduling conflicts with other events; new class time (if convenient for everyone): Fri, 9:30 am – 12:00 pm;
- the Oct 5 class needs to be rescheduled;
- there is a CourseWork site for the class, where readings, handouts etc. are / will be available.

Topic 1 (weeks 1 – 3): Introduction to compositional dynamic semantics

- static approaches equate the meaning of a sentence with its truth conditions, i.e. the circumstances in which a sentence is true or false;
- dynamic approaches have a finer-grained conception of meaning: the meaning of a sentence is its context change potential, i.e. the way in which it changes / updates a (discourse) context;
- the fact that natural language interpretation is context *dependent* is explicitly investigated in both kinds of approaches, e.g. in an out-of-the-blue utterance of *A house elf injured Hermione*, the time of the injury is contextually determined;
- only dynamic approaches systematically investigate how the interpretation of a natural language expression *changes* the context, i.e. it *creates* a new context out of the old one and thus affects how subsequent expressions are interpreted, e.g. we can further elaborate on the injury situation described above with the sentence *But he didn't mean to*, where the pronoun *he* is interpreted as referring to the previously mentioned house elf.

Kinds of phenomena that motivate dynamic approaches to natural language interpretation:

- cross-sentential anaphora (to individuals, temporal intervals etc.):
 1. A^x man came^t in. He_x sat_t down.
- donkey anaphora: relative-clause donkey sentences and conditional donkey sentences
 2. Every^x farmer who owns a^y donkey beats it_y. (based on Geach 1962)
 3. If a^x farmer owns a^y donkey, he_x beats it_y.
- quantificational subordination:

4. Most^x books contain a^y table of contents. In some_x^z, it_y is at the end_z. (Heim 1990)
5. Harvey^x courts a^y girl at every^z convention. She_y always_z comes^e to the banquet_z with him_x. The_y girl is usually_z^{z'} also^e very pretty. (Karttunen 1976)
- modal subordination:
 6. A^x wolf might^w come in. It_x would_w eat Harvey first. (based on Roberts 1989)
 7. John^x thinks^w that he_x will_w catch a^y fish and he_x hopes_w^{w'} I will_{w'} grill it_y tonight.
 8. [A] man cannot live without joy. Therefore, when he is deprived of true spiritual joys, it is necessary that he become addicted to carnal pleasures. (attributed to Thomas Aquinas)
 9. If^w a^x man is alive, he_x must_w find something pleasurable / he_x must_w have a pleasure. Therefore, if_w^{w'} he_x doesn't have any spiritual pleasure, he_x must_{w'} have a carnal pleasure.
 10. Hob thinks^w a^x witch has blighted Bob's mare and Nob thinks^{w'} she_x killed cob's sow (based on Geach 1962)

Readings:

- Background – (static) Montague semantics: Montague (1974), Dowty, Wall & Peters (1981)
- Lewis (1975), Kamp (1981) – Discourse Representation Theory, Heim (1983) – File Change Semantics
- Groenendijk & Stokhof (1991) – Dynamic Predicate Logic (see also Brasoveanu 2007: ch. 2)
- Muskens (1996) & Brasoveanu (2007): ch. 3-4 – Compositional DRT with generalized quantification

Topic 2 (weeks 4 – 7): Indefinites and their scopal properties

Another phenomenon involving indefinites and a syntax/semantics 'mismatch': exceptional wide scope.

11. Every^x student of mine read every^y poem that a^z famous Romanian poet wrote before World War II.
12. Narrowest scope indefinite:

$$\forall x(student.o.m(x) \rightarrow \forall y(poem(y) \wedge \exists z(r.poet(z) \wedge write(z, y)) \rightarrow read(x, y)))$$
13. Intermediate scope indefinite:

$$\forall x(student.o.m(x) \rightarrow \exists z(r.poet(z) \wedge \forall y(poem(y) \wedge write(z, y) \rightarrow read(x, y))))$$
14. Context for the intermediate scope reading:
 Every^{x'} student chose a^{z'} poet and read every^{y'} poem written by him_z.
15. Widest scope indefinite:

$$\exists z(r.poet(z) \wedge \forall x(student.o.m(x) \rightarrow \forall y(poem(y) \wedge write(z, y) \rightarrow read(x, y))))$$

16. Context for the widest scope reading:

Every^{x'} student chose a^{z'} poet – the same_{z'} poet – and read every^{y'} poem written by him_{z'}.

Readings:

- Introduction: Hawkins (1991), Heim (1991)
- Exceptional wide scope: Farkas (1981), Fodor & Sag (1982)
- Accounts: [Abusch (1994), Farkas (1997)], Reinhart (1997), Winter (1997), [Kratzer (1998)], Matthewson (1999), [Chierchia (2001)], Schwarzschild (2002), [Kamp & Bende-Farkas (2006), Schlenker (2006)], Steedman (2007), Brasoveanu & Farkas (2007)

Topic 3 (weeks 8 – 10): 'Unusual' indefinites and indefinites cross-linguistically (we will discuss only a couple of papers, if any)

For example: wh-indefinites in Hindi and Romanian correlatives (), which exhibit a universal vs. definite variation in interpretation. This variation is parallel to the universal vs. definite interpretation of donkey sentences – compare (2) above and (21) below.

- **Correlatives** – "biclausal topic-comment structures [...] [in which] the dependent clause introduces one or more topical referents to be commented on by the matrix clause, where each topical referent must be picked up by — correlated with — an anaphoric proform." (Bittner 2001: 4). The Hindi examples are from / based on Dayal (1996).

17. jo^x laRkii lambii hai, vo_x khaRii hai.
which girl tall be.prs, she standing be.prs
The one girl that is tall is standing.

18. jis^x laRkii-ne jis^y laRke-ke saath khel-aa, us_x-ne us_y-ko haraa-yaa.
which girl-Erg which boy-with together play-pfv, she-Erg he-Acc defeat-pfv
Every girl that played against a boy is such that she played against exactly one boy and she defeated the one boy she played against.

19. Care^x fată e înaltă, (aceea_x) stă în picioare.
which girl is tall, (that one) stands on legs
Every girl that is tall is standing (or: stands up).

20. Care^x fată împotriva căru^y băiat a jucat, l_y =a bătut.
which girl against which.Gen boy HAVE played, HIM=HAVE defeated. Every girl that played against a boy defeated every boy she played against.

21. Every^x man who has a^y son wills him_y all his_x money.
(Parsons 1978, attributed to B. Partee)

Readings:

- see the CourseWork site;
- ?Invited lecture: proper names as indefinites (Sam Cumming, UCLA, Philosophy)

Topic 4 (weeks 8 – 10): Indefinites, adverbs of quantification and focus (we will discuss only a couple of papers, if any)

Indefinites can be 'bound' by an adverb of quantification in their context. Moreover, the two arguments of the adverb of quantification, i.e. the restrictor and the nuclear scope, are obtained based on the focus-background partition of the sentence.

The French and English examples below are from de Swart (1993).

- 22. Anne se promène toujours [au Luxembourg]_F.
- 23. Anne always takes a walk [in the Luxembourg garden]_F.
- 24. All situations in which Anne takes a walk are such that she takes a walk in the Luxembourg garden.
- 25. Georges écrit rarement [avec un stylo rouge]_F.
- 26. Georges seldom writes [with a red pencil]_F.
- 27. Few of the situations in which Georges writes are such that he writes with a red pencil.

Readings:

- see the CourseWork site.

Evaluation:

- in-class presentation of one or two readings (one or two – to be decided depending on how fast we go and how many people are registered); joint presentations are acceptable and encouraged (but you will have to present as many papers as there are people in your group); requirements:
 - handout(s) & meeting with the instructor to discuss the pre-final version of the handout(s);
 - email the instructor with the title of the (first) paper you intend to present by Oct 12;
- final paper / project; requirements:
 - a two-page abstract submitted by Nov 9 – follow the *Sinn und Bedeutung* (SuB) guidelines available here:
<http://www.hf.uio.no/ilos/forskning/konferanser/SuB12/submission.html>;
 - an in-class presentation of the final paper on Dec 7 (last class) – SuB-style, i.e. 45 minutes (35 minutes – presentation & 10 minutes – discussion), with a handout or slides; schedule a meeting with the instructor to discuss the pre-final version of the handout / slides;
 - submission of the final paper by Dec 10; the submission should strictly adhere to the SuB guidelines available here:

There will be no incompletes. I will assign a grade based on what you (fail to) submit by Dec 10, 2007.

- the amount of work you need to do is proportional to the number of credits you are registered for: 4 credits – all requirements; 3 credits – everything but the final paper; 2 credits – everything but the final paper and the in-class presentation.

Here are some possible topics for the final paper (but you are strongly encouraged to explore any other ideas you might have). Joint papers are acceptable and encouraged; contact the instructor to determine the requirements for a joint paper.

- designing a syntax-semantics interface between one of the dynamic semantics systems we discuss in class and your favorite syntactic framework; the paper needs to focus on a phenomenon (or class of phenomena) that the resulting syn/sem interface can successfully analyze and compare the analysis with alternative analyses in the previous literature;
- an investigation of a particular kind of indefinites, preferably in a language other than English (plus comparison with other indefinites in English & other languages): phenomena, analysis etc.
- corpus investigation of a particular kind of indefinite – the range of readings, proposal of analysis in one of the frameworks discussed in class, evaluation of the framework based on the collected data etc.
- for more ideas, see the readings on the CourseWork site under topics 3 and 4.

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